

Common Core State Standards and English Learners

The primary goal of the Common Core State Standards Initiative is to prepare students for postsecondary education and the workforce. The Common Core State Standards (CCSS) are designed to ensure that all students graduate from high school with the knowledge and skills they need to be successful (National Governors Association Center for Best Practices and Council of Chief State School Officers, 2010).

Basic Tenets of the Common Core State Standards

- Set high expectations for all students
- Advocate rigorous content
- Advocate the use of higher-order thinking skills

Meeting the Language Challenges Presented by Text Complexity

A Systematic Response

Dr. Kenji Hakuta, a professor of education at Stanford University, and Delia Pompa, an educator with experience with ELs and school reform, and other specialists in English language acquisition have been working to determine how ELs can be successful with the CCSS. They believe that many of the challenges in dealing with the language of complex texts are actually shared by all students (2012). Reaching this understanding of the role of language leads to an important question.

Pompa and Hakuta ask: How should the states address the way in which CCSS and ELP (English language proficiency) standards correspond?

Their answer: A systematic response that *meaningfully* aligns CCSS and ELP is required.

The next obvious question revolves around what a systematic response would look like. The following chart outlines Pompa and Hakuta's recommendations to state policy makers.

Systematic Response to CCSS-ELP Correspondence

- Teaching to higher expectations and appropriately assessing both language and content for ELs involves alignment of the following with CCSS:
 - Curriculum and instruction
 - Teacher preparation and professional development
 - Assessment
- Valid and reliable assessments that address the language functions required to engage with the kinds of content outlined in the CCSS should be developed and implemented.
- Assessment and accountability systems should address both language and content in order to have value for ELs as well as native English speakers.
- All teachers should receive preservice and professional development to teach ELs effectively.
- Strategies for engaging parents/families and the community should be developed and implemented.

Close Reading One Sentence at a Time

Lily Wong Fillmore, Professor Emerita at the University of California, Berkeley, has been working to discover why so many language minority students struggle to advance beyond basic levels of reading proficiency. Fillmore and Charles J. Fillmore, Professor Emeritus of Linguistics at the University of California, Berkeley, support the idea that language is the key to comprehending the level of text complexity advocated by CCSS:

Given the language diversity in our schools and in our classrooms, any effort to make the CCSS attainable for these and many other students must go beyond vocabulary, and should begin with an examination of our beliefs about language, literacy and learning (2012).

Fillmore and Fillmore emphasize that complex texts differ from ordinary language. It is a type of language not often found in everyday conversation—even in the classroom. The only place that students are likely to encounter the type of language used in complex texts is in the complex texts themselves. As a result, the only way students can learn the academic language of complex texts is by studying complex texts.

ELs can understand the ideas presented in complex texts with instructional support that includes a close study of one sentence at a time (Fillmore & Fillmore, 2012). The goal is for students to break down the dense content in a given sentence into its component parts.

Basis for Sentence Selection

- Has a high level of complexity
- Is grammatically interesting
- Relates to focal point of passage

Establishing higher expectations and mandating that all students—including ELs—meet those expectations, may seem a daunting task; however, it's not insurmountable. The clear, consistent understanding of educational expectations outlined in the CCSS provides a framework around which teachers can build lessons. When used in tandem with a systematic approach to assessment, instruction, and professional development, ELs can meet the challenges presented by the Common Core State Standards.